

SENATE RESOLUTION 243

By Akbari

A RESOLUTION to honor and commend Kenneth Whalum III of Memphis.

WHEREAS, Kenneth Whalum III is a singular creative voice in contemporary music, an artist whose saxophone speaks as powerfully as his pen and whose vocal stylings redefine the boundaries of jazz, alt-soul, and spiritual expression; and

WHEREAS, born and raised in the rich musical landscape of Memphis, Tennessee, Kenneth is a product of deep-rooted artistry, spiritual tradition, and relentless innovation. As a composer, arranger, bandleader, and tenor saxophonist, he is acclaimed for his ability to synthesize gospel roots with jazz dexterity, R&B rhythms, and soulful introspection; and

WHEREAS, Kenneth's musical path was shaped early by the vibrant sounds of Memphis and the influence of his family. His father, Reverend Kenneth T. Whalum Jr., is a respected pastor and musician; his uncle, Kirk Whalum, is a Grammy-winning saxophonist whose work has defined generations; and

WHEREAS, Kenneth initially gravitated toward drums but was persuaded by a middle school band director to pick up the saxophone. That pivotal decision unlocked a calling; from church performances at The New Olivet Baptist Church to gigs around town, Kenneth's musical journey has always been grounded in purpose and community; and

WHEREAS, his artistry deepened through formal education—first at Morehouse College, then at The New School for Jazz and Contemporary Music in New York, where he was immersed in the epicenter of modern jazz. There, Kenneth developed a bold and emotional sound, collaborating with peers like Robert Glasper, Bilal, and Chris "Daddy" Dave; and

WHEREAS, his debut album, *To Those Who Believe*, captures the soul of that journey: a deeply personal exploration of faith, struggle, joy, and growth, woven together with world-class musicianship and lyrical sensitivity; and

WHEREAS, Kenneth's career as a session and touring artist skyrocketed with early stints performing with Sean "Diddy" Combs and Jay-Z, the latter of whom featured Kenneth's horn arrangements on the chart-topping "Roc Boys (And the Winner Is)"; from there, his saxophone became a sought-after voice in the industry, appearing on projects with Maxwell, Mary J. Blige, Beyoncé, Al Green, 50 Cent, and more. His work on *BLACKSummers'night* with Maxwell earned Grammy nominations, cementing his place among music's most elite collaborators; and

WHEREAS, but Kenneth's heart lies in his solo work. His haunting single "Say Sorry" and soul-stirring track "One More Kiss" highlight his evolution as a vocalist and songwriter. With an ear for atmospheric production, lyrical honesty, and spiritual resonance, Kenneth Whalum doesn't just play music—he ministers through it; and

WHEREAS, now based in Brooklyn, New York, Kenneth continues to explore the intersections of faith, identity, and artistry. His music offers solace, provokes thought, and stands as a living tribute to Memphis soul, jazz intellect, and personal truth; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE SENATE OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, that we honor and commend Kenneth Whalum III for his indelible contributions to music and extend to him our best wishes for much continued success.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy.